

Why Did My Organic Traffic Suddenly Drop?

A 4-step diagnostic checklist and a 3-step recovery plan.

THE 3 USUAL SUSPECTS

Algorithm update

A Google core or spam update reshuffled rankings.

Tracking error

Analytics code broke, so the drop is not real.

Accidental noindex

A stray tag or robots rule hid pages from Google.

THE 4-STEP DIAGNOSTIC

1 Rule out tracking glitches

- View source: is the GA4 tag (G-XXXX) present, once?
- Visit your site with GA4 Realtime open.
- Check Tag Manager for recent publishes.
- If Search Console clicks are flat but GA fell, it is tracking.

2 Check Google Search Console

- Manual actions and Security issues reports.
- Pages report: spikes in noindex, 404, server errors.
- URL Inspection on your top pages.
- Confirm robots.txt and canonicals unchanged.

3 Analyze keyword volatility

- GSC Performance: compare equal date ranges.
- Sort by Pages, then Queries.
- Ahrefs or Semrush: check Top Pages and lost rankings.
- Sitewide drop: technical or algorithm. Few pages: content, links, competitors.

4 Algorithmic or technical?

- Match the drop date to Google's Search Status Dashboard.
- Inside an update window: likely algorithmic.
- Matches a deploy or migration: likely technical.
- Wait a full week after rollout ends before judging.

CONFIRMED GOOGLE UPDATES IN 2026

Feb 5-27

Mar 27-Apr 8

May 21-Jun 2

Aug 18-21

From Sep 24

Discover core

March core

May core

Aug spam

Sep spam

Core updates are not penalties, and Google says they have no specific fix.

3-STEP RECOVERY PLAN

1. Fix what is broken

Restore tracking, remove stray noindex, repair redirects, request re-indexing.

2. Improve affected pages

Add original data, firsthand experience and clear answers to lost pages.

3. Monitor and document

Annotate the drop date, track rankings weekly, review after next update.